Here With Oca

by

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???
Rolling in three, two...

EXT. BACKYARD - DAY

UPBEAT. A 'two-person' interview shot.

On the left is **BRIAR:** human, olive-green jacket, scruffy hair, and slanted when she sits. On the right is **OCA:** seated primly, baggy tux, and would look human enough if not for the WHITE CIRCLE (SUPER) that conspicuously covers their face.

Briar holds her LAV MIC up to Oca.

BRIAR
I'm here with?

OCA
Oca.

TITLE CARD (SUPER): *"Here With Oca"*

BRIAR
(to camera)
An actual fallen angel, you guys!
(to Oca)
How was the landing, Oca?

INT. BEDROOM - LAST NIGHT

LAPTOP SCREEN: on it, a FLUFF ARTICLE currently being edited. On the wall (BG) is a CALENDAR, with one big "X" on Monday.

OCA (V.O.)
Oh, it was fine.

Briar's blue-lit face is behind the screen, eyes squinting. MOONLIGHT shines through the window.

OCA (V.O.)
I have no bones so it didn't hurt at all.

A FLASH OF LIGHT OUTSIDE - BANG! Briar falls out her chair.

EXT. BACKYARD - LAST NIGHT, MOMENTS LATER

Briar comes out of the backyard door. Her eyes widen.

BRIAR (V.O.)
You said you were here for...

On the grass is a BALL OF LIGHT - which becomes a crouching Oca, who slowly rises up to stand. Hands behind their back.

BRIAR (V.O.)
... Sightseeing, right?

Oca puts up one hand.

OCA (IN FLASHBACK)
Don't be afraid.

BACK TO: EXT. BACKYARD - DAY

OCA
(nods)
Yes, that's right.

BRIAR
And you're only sticking around for, what, a day?

OCA
Before I turn to stone, yes.

Beat. Briar turns to the camera with a deadpan smile.

EXT. FOREST - DAY

TREES OVERHEAD. Oca admires them as they stroll through - Briar walks in front, mind somewhere else, SWINGING her HANDHELD CAMERA by it's strap.

BRIAR
Then every moment's material...

She then SWIVELS around to record Oca with her handheld, walking BACKWARDS. A 'tracking' shot.

BEEP! - Oca SEEN THROUGH THE CAMERA VIEWPORT, handheld shake.

BRIAR (O.S.)
Oca! Put our imaginations to rest and tell us: what's the afterlife <u>really</u> look like?

OCA
Oh. Well, from what I can recall...

ANIMATION 1 <

WHITE SCREEN. Doodles of a DOG, a CAT, MISC. ANIMALS/PLANTS and a HUMAN CHILD pop up sequentially, *following Oca's V.O.*

OCA (V.O.)
There were dogs. And cats. Many other organisms, and... children.

ALL OF THEM on one screen. It looks like a playground.

OCA (V.O.)
Eternity is quite full of them.

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Briar knelt behind a CAMERA ON TRIPOD, scrolling through a WIKIPEDIA page on her phone.

BRIAR
(looking at phone)
Huh. No pearly gates, or... gardens beneath which rivers flow? Oca?

She turns back to the camera: Oca is sat on a COUCH, drawing.

OCA
(looking down, drawing)
There may have been, I'm not sure.

BRIAR
... You're drawing.

OCA
Yes. Visuals aid my memory.

Briar scratches her head, a forced chuckle.

BRIAR
Um--

EXT. FOREST - DAY

Back to the 'tracking' shot. Briar points at Oca's face.

BRIAR
Hey! That thing on your face! What is it?

OCA
It's a censor only humans can see.

BRIAR
Censor? C'mon, your face would look great on a thumbnail! Lemme get a peek.

OCA
I'm... not sure, Briar. That may melt your cerebrum.

BRIAR (O.S.)
Ah.

EXT. BACKYARD - DAY

Back to the 'two-person' shot.

BRIAR
But you can change your body, right? Being boneless and all?

Oca raises their hand - SNAP! - and BECOMES BRIAR (SPLIT PLATE), albeit with the face censor. Briar nods, stiffly.

OCA (BRIAR'S VOICE)
Yes.

BRIAR
Cool, so... are there others like you out there? Any disguised as, say, presidents or tech company CEOs?

OCA (BRIAR'S VOICE)
Most likely not.

OCA (CONT'D)
Since we turn to stone after 24 hours--

BRIAR
Right, 'cause of that...

INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Briar behind the tripod camera. Intent in her eyes.

BRIAR
Then, it's probably time I ask...
(savours the words)
Why <u>did</u> you fall, Oca? What divine offence got you kicked out of eternity?

Oca looks off, pensively. Feels serious all of a sudden.

OCA
... I <u>envied</u>. Wanted something I wasn't meant to. It was...

A SWELL...

OCA (CONT'D)
... Oh my I forgot what.

THE VIEWPORT GOES BLACK.

BRIAR (O.S.)
What!? Ah, fuck!

Briar steps back. Her "media-friendly" voice has dropped.

OCA (O.S.)
Sorry, Briar.

BRIAR
The battery just died.

Briar takes the BATTERY out of the camera, and walks off to the right - we see LIGHTING STANDS as we FOLLOW her into an unlit part of the room, where the BATTERY CHARGER is.

OCA (O.S.)
Oh? It had once lived?

BRIAR
(while walking)
No-- it's just a thing, Oca, not like trees which apparently have lived experiences or whatever...

Briar kneels down to the charger, tries to JAM the battery in, but it doesn't click. Keeps trying. Holds her voice back.

BRIAR (CONT'D)
Look. I'm thankful that you agreed to do this, but... how does an angel get amnesia? How exactly do you get concussed without bones?

CLICK! - battery's in. She lets out a HUFF. Oca shrinks.

OCA
... As I said before, Briar, the entropy on Earth severs my link to eternal knowledge. Think of it like your... oh, what was it...
(puts finger up)
Your wi-fi!

Briar walks the length of the room to get to the KITCHEN (O.S.) on the other side, passing the couch where Oca sits.

BRIAR
(walking until O.S.)
Yeah, okay-- as soon as anyone hears "entropy" they're checking out. That's not a flashy word.

OCA
I... suppose it does lack some spectacle.

Briar pops back out with a MUESLI BAR, points it at Oca and CLICKS HER TONGUE in approval.

BRIAR
But not just spectacle. Novelty. The afterlife system, god's middle name; that's new. That gets clicks! Nobody clicks on the human stuff that they know already.

OCA
Clicks. I see.

Briar SLUMPS herself on the couch. She unwraps the muesli bar, starts EATING it, trying to wind down. Beat.

BRIAR
(mouthful, slurred)
You'll be a hit, Oca. My big page one hit-- not page two. Page one. 'Cause... you're a real freakin' angel, and people'll eat that up.

OCA
I'm grateful to be that for you.

Briar turns her gaze to the battery charger (CU). Then at the clock (CU). TICK, TICK, TICK. She gulps, and bites again.

OCA (O.S.)
But, I'm also curious... why do you want to make this piece at all, Briar?

She chews nervously, not hearing Oca - then she jolts up.

BRIAR
(coughing)
Oh! There's a power cord somewhere!

Briar hurries out of the room. RUMMAGING is heard.

Briar elsewhere, Oca stands up and MEANDERS around the room, hands behind back; bending down to look closer at the camera setup and VARIOUS DECOR, as LIGHT PIANO kicks in. A FLOWER VASE, a PHOTOGRAPH OF BRIAR, then a PAINTING. Oca pauses.

OCA
... I remember now.

Briar comes running out of the corner - holding a CORD like a snake wrangler - but stops after hearing what Oca said.

INT. BEDROOM - DAY

DOWNBEAT. SUNLIGHT THROUGH THE WINDOW. The room is cramped. Briar is crouched down behind the camera tripod; angled at Oca, sat on the BED for a more casual 'talking head'.

BRIAR
Let's hear it, Oca.

Oca SEEN THROUGH THE VIEWPORT.

BRIAR (O.S.)
Who did you envy? Is it who we're all thinking?

Oca shakes their head.

OCA
No. It was nobody in particular. Rather, a concept, foreign to me...

Briar ZOOMS in to Oca. It's overly dramatic.

OCA (CONT'D)
... The human experience.

A snicker from Briar as she adjusts the focus.

BRIAR
Wow. Care to elaborate on that?
(away from mic, whisper)
Monologue style!

Beat. Oca ponders on it.

OCA
Eternity was perfect.

ANIMATION 2 <

SIDESCROLL of HUMANS IN SUITS, each doing VARIOUS ACTIVITIES (golf, computer, flying a rocket, etc.) with BORED faces.

OCA (V.O.)
Too perfect. There were no goals to have in infinite time. Nothing to do with all the miracles. Every soul opts out, eventually.

One by one, they RAISE THEIR HAND - which DISINTEGRATES them.

> BACK TO: INT. BEDROOM - DAY

BRIAR
Except kids, pets and plants?

OCA
(nods)
They don't get bored of things.

ANIMATION 3 <

FRONT SHOT of Oca, idle, which ABSTRACTLY PANS to Oca looking down at the EARTH, somehow beneath their feet.

OCA (V.O.)
And so, as I watched life on Earth, I couldn't help but notice...

VARIOUS STILLS (improvised), *following Oca's V.O.*

OCA (V.O.)
Change. Failure, and growth. Works of art being made for the first time. Hugs, shared for the last. And <u>memories</u>, everywhere.

Oca leans forward - starts to FALL THROUGH the white space, accelerating, BURNING UP INTO A COMET--

OCA (V.O.)
In lifetimes, in passing moments... humans made their meaning. I wanted to see that meaning in myself, too.

> BACK TO: INT. BEDROOM - DAY

OCA (CONT'D)
If only for one day...

Beat. Briar's face, covered by the camera, is DAZED - before she looks up at Oca with her usual smirk. BEEP! Thumbs up.

BRIAR
Nice words!

Briar stands up, dismounts the camera from the tripod.

BRIAR (CONT'D)
Imagine that title, though. *"Angel leaves heaven to experience a day in Mount Druitt"*! It's funny.

Suddenly, Oca's hand drifts in front of Briar's face, holding a sheet of PAPER. On it, a CRUDE DRAWING OF HER with the caption: "BRIAR, BRIGHT SMILE".

BRIAR (CONT'D)
What's that?

OCA
I made a drawing of you.

Briar stares. Gives a NOD. Clears her throat, then LOOKS AWAY and pops out the SD CARD from the camera. She moves over to her LAPTOP on the desk, uploads the card.

BRIAR
(not looking)
So is that, like, a holy relic, technically?

OCA
It's art, so it's up to you.

BRIAR
(to self, jokingly)
They think I'm art.

LAPTOP SCREEN: a folder with FRAMES OF OCA that pop up. The CURSOR drags the files from one folder to another.

OCA (O.S.)
You must enjoy making your videos, Briar.

BRIAR (O.S.)
Uh, no, this is... a side project. I write for work. Just trying something new.

OCA (O.S.)
How nice. Is it something you've always wanted to do?

Briar turns back to Oca, a raised eyebrow.

BRIAR
I thought I was interviewing you?

OCA
Well, it would be quite novel for you to talk about yourself. Hm-hm!

Briar snickers. She moves to the tripod, begins to take it down and stow it in a TRIPOD BAG, her back turned to Oca. Keeping hands busy.

BRIAR
(while packing)
Yeah, uh... I guess when I was a kid I wanted to be, like, a real journalist. Y'know, field reports, docs on war crimes... stuff that... actually meant something. I dunno.

OCA
... You aren't a real journalist?

BRIAR
Apparently I'm a hack writer--

Briar ZIPS UP the tripod bag, a harsh sound. Beat.

OCA (O.S.)
Labels are not inherent things, Briar.

No response. Oca leans forward, soft posture.

OCA
If this matters to you, why not make it for the simple reason... that it does? Why let a faceless mass give you meaning, when you can give that to yourself?

Briar's hand, CLENCHING the bag, slowly loosens. Head droops.

BRIAR
... Because I'm not a concept, Oca. I'm <u>malleable</u>.

She slings the bag over her shoulder, and trudges over to the door, swinging it open. An exhale. She looks back at Oca - a softer look - and holds up her camera.

BRIAR (CONT'D)
C'mon. Let's get some b-roll.

B-ROLL: INT. LIVING ROOM - DAY

Oca poses, sitting cross-legged on the couch, as Briar shoots them from different angles.

OCA (V.O.)
I... still do hope people like me.

B-ROLL: EXT. STREET - DAY

Oca on the street beside a TELEPHONE POLE. A CAR passes by.

BRIAR (V.O.)
They will. You'll get a bajillion likes, and... you'll be remembered forever, thanks to the internet.

Briar filming them, on the other side of the street.

BRIAR (V.O.)
I'll watch you every now and then.

B-ROLL: EXT. FOREST - DAY

Oca plays PEEK-A-BOO, hopping between the trees.

OCA (V.O.)
(soft chuckle)
That would be nice. Although...

EXT. PLAYGROUND - LATE - PRESENT MOMENT

Briar and Oca sat on a BENCH. Briar's feet TAP. She checks her phone: A DEADLINE ALARM COUNTING DOWN, realer than ever.

OCA (V.O.)
... I hope that, every now and then, you'll go out of your way to remember me...

She looks left to see Oca suddenly standing by the SWINGS, waving their hand.

OCA (V.O.)
With that fleshy brain of yours!

Briar shakes her head, SCOFFS. A light grin.

BRIAR (V.O.)
Okay. I will. As long as entropy doesn't mess me up, too.

Oca WOOS and LAUGHS with a childlike whimsy, as Briar PUSHES them on the swing. She laughs as well.

BRIAR (V.O.)
Sorry you couldn't go sightseeing, Oca.

OCA (V.O.)
Don't be. I saw what I wanted to.

Oca goes up and down, and up and down. The music SWELLS. A big PUSH and--

QUIET. The SKY, in slo-mo, as a SMALL STONE flies overhead.

The stone lands on the ground (FG), further away from Briar and the empty swing (BG). Briar slowly walks up to the stone, stands in front for a beat, then kneels down to it's level.

The stone looks like any other. But it makes Briar smile.

ROLL CREDITS.

The credits show snippets of hate comments from Briar's (unseen) piece, including accusations of making the angel "woke" and "gay", the angel "being AI", and so on.

This is accompanied by light piano.